

Wellbeing in the School Library

Rachael Brennan

A career change and a neglected library meant there was an opportunity for development, and wellbeing is at the heart of a school library with purpose and community.

Despite all the challenges that came with it, the COVID-19 pandemic had a silver lining for me: it inspired me to pursue a lifelong ambition of becoming a school librarian. As the world reopened its doors, I enrolled in a master's degree programme in Library and Information Services Management at Sheffield University (@InfoSchoolSheff). I previously worked as a primary school teaching assistant, a role I thoroughly enjoyed, but it felt like the right time to finally follow my dream.

After gaining experience working under the wing of an inspirational school librarian at Stockport Grammar School, I was offered the role of Librarian at Stonyhurst College in September 2022. I had to pinch myself as I approached the magnificent Grade I listed building on my first day at work. The More Library was equally as impressive, an expansive space with traditional decorative features, but the College had not employed a dedicated librarian for several years and I soon realised there was a substantial development project ahead of me. This presented an exciting opportunity, and I was eager to bring some of my own ideas to the role and make meaningful contributions to the historic library's future.

It was immediately apparent that the library functioned mainly as a silent study space, and I understood the importance of this in a school where a large percentage of pupils reside on campus. The library provides a calm, quiet environment, away from lively boarding houses and playrooms, particularly in the lead up to coursework deadlines and examination periods.

However, I believed that the library had the potential to provide greater benefits. Through the research I had carried out during my academic studies, I had developed a good understanding of the critical role libraries play in supporting students' mental health and wellbeing. I felt that, in addition to its traditional functions, the library at Stonyhurst had the potential to serve as a welcoming and inclusive "third place" to support the social and emotional needs of pupils, particularly in a setting where home and school life are often blurred.

I began with small changes to create a more relaxed and inviting space. I streamlined and reorganised some of the more cluttered areas and revamped all the displays and signage so that it felt more modern and relevant to our current pupils. I added a few plants and hung-up some motivational posters and artwork. Unfortunately, you cannot see directly into the library from the school corridor, so I acquired a



Rachael Brennan became College Librarian at Stonyhurst College in 2022 upon completing an MA in Library & Information Management at Sheffield University. Passionate about creating student-centred library spaces, Rachael's journey continues with a Professional Doctorate in Creative Media Education at Bournemouth University sponsored by the SLA.



Wellbeing is a visible presence in the school library.